



UNIVERSITEIT VAN PRETORIA
UNIVERSITY OF PRETORIA
YUNIBESITHI YA PRETORIA

Faculty of Engineering, Built Environment and Information Technology

Fakulteit Ingenieurswese, Bou-omgewing en
Inligtingtegnologie / Lefapha la Boetšenere,
Tikologo ya Kago le Theknološi ya Tshedimošo



Self-Study 1a: Conflict and Team Dynamics

BSS 310 Engineering Management 2026

Lecturer: Prof. Michael Ayomoh

Quick Recap/Questions arising from Previous Lecture

- Overview of the module and its road map was presented
- Project work introductory overview was presented based on the stipulated requirements of the rubrics and in line with ECSA's Graduate Attributes (GA11).

Expected Learning Outcomes for the Current Lecture

The expected learning outcomes herein include:

- Having a clear understanding, and being able to apply, analyse, and evaluate the concept of “Needs Analysis” and its subsidiary elements in respect of business systems design and management.
- Being able to apply this knowledge to the conceptual design of a new business system in the real world.

Learning Outcomes for the Current Lecture

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Address the basics of Conflict via the definition of Conflict and **understanding** a few facts about Conflict in Project Management
- **Understand** types of Conflicts
- **Understand** the Causes of Conflicts in Project Management and approaches towards addressing Conflict in Project Management and Teamwork
- **Apply** knowledge acquired herein during the course of the semester group work

BLOOM'S TAXONOMY & EXPECTED LEVELS of COGNITION

BLOOM'S TAXONOMY



Presentation Outline

- Introduction
- Definition of Conflict
- Some Facts about Conflict in Project Management
- Types of Conflict
- Causes of Conflicts
- Approaches to Addressing Conflict in Project Management

Introduction

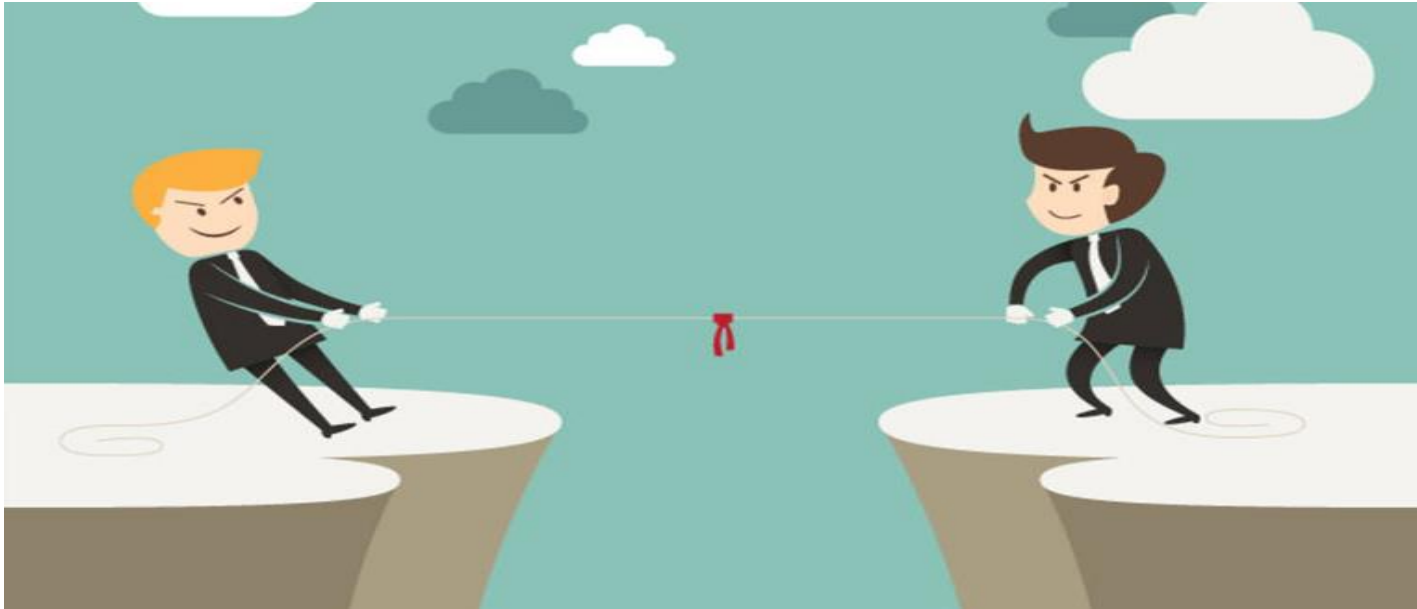
- **Preamble:** Having commenced a group project recently, what is your experience like interacting and working with group members?
- Peaceful! No issues
- Argumentative! Resolved afterwards
- Terrible! Almost led to a break-up; One or two uncooperative members

One group on paper but two or more groups in reality



Battle Royal: The line is drawn

Who is acting right?



My approach is correct please

Definition of Conflict

What is Conflict?

- Conflict is serious disagreement and argument about something important. If two people or groups are in conflict, they have had a serious disagreement or argument and have not yet reached agreement.

<https://www.collinsdictionary.com/dictionary/english/conflict>

- It is a relational dispute between two or more parties. “The clashing of opposed principles- *Oxford Dictionary*”

What is Conflict?

- **Conflict** is defined as a clash between individuals arising out of a difference in thought process, attitudes, understanding, interests, requirements and even sometimes perceptions. ...
<https://www.managementstudyguide.com/understanding-conflict.htm>
- An active disagreement between people with opposing opinions or principles
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/conflict>

Some Facts about Conflict in Project Management

Some Facts about Conflict in Project Management

- Conflict is a way of life in a project structure and can generally occur at any level in the organization, usually as a result of conflicting objectives.
- In the project environment, conflicts are inevitable. Conflicts occur because people on the project team may have different values, interests, feelings, and goals. **Project managers that cannot resolve these conflicts in a timely manner are doomed to failure.** Some conflicts can be resolved quickly while others may take much longer to resolve.
- Personality conflict can be much more difficult to resolve. Ideally, the project manager should report to someone high enough up to get timely assistance in resolving conflicts.

Some Facts about Conflict in Project Management

- **Sometimes conflict is “meaningful” and produces beneficial results.** These meaningful conflicts should be permitted to continue as long as project constraints are not violated and beneficial results are being received.
 - An example of this is two technical specialists arguing that each has a better way of solving a problem, and each trying to find additional supporting data for his hypothesis. At this point, conflict can ensue between these specialists.
- The project manager might wish to **concede on a low-intensity conflict** if he knows that a **high-intensity conflict** is expected to occur at a later point in the project.

Some Facts about Conflict in Project Management

Conflicts can occur with anyone and over anything. Some people contend that personality conflicts are the most difficult to resolve. Ideally, the project manager should report to someone high enough up to get timely assistance in resolving conflicts. Unfortunately, this is easier said than done. Therefore, project managers must plan for conflict resolution.

Types of Conflicts

Types of Conflicts

The repelling force that results in **conflict** is often categorised into four basic types viz:

- Conflict with self,
- Conflict with others,
- Conflict with the environment and
- Conflict with the supernatural.

Conflict with self, considered as the internal battle is often the most powerful.

<https://www.writersdigest.com/write-better-fiction/script-classics-conflict-core-four-types-conflict>

Types of Conflicts...Contd.

Each of these conflicts can **vary in relative intensity over the life cycle of a project**. However, project managers believe that the **most frequently occurring conflicts are over schedules** but the **potentially damaging conflicts can occur over personality clashes**. The relative intensity can vary as a function of:

- Getting closer to project constraints
- Having only two constraints instead of three (i.e., time and performance, but not cost)
- The project life cycle itself
- The person with whom the conflict occurs

Causes of Conflicts

Causes of Conflict in Project Management

- **It is impossible to develop a list of all the different types of conflicts that can exist on each and every project. All projects differ in size, scope, and complexity. The most common types of conflicts involve:**
 - Staffing resources
 - Equipment and facilities
 - Capital expenditures
 - Costs
 - Technical opinions and trade-offs
 - Priorities
 - Administrative procedures
 - Scheduling
 - Responsibilities
 - Personality clashes

Causes of Conflicts in Project Management

- **There are several causes of conflicts.**

- **First**, project managers have historically been brought on board the project after the business case has been prepared. As a result, the business case, schedule, cost, assumptions, and other constraints are imposed upon the project team. All of this happens well before a detailed project plan is prepared.
- **Second**, companies often approve projects without any consideration being given to **capacity planning** and whether or **not qualified resources** will be available once the project begins. This is particularly true for companies that survive on competitive bidding. These companies may have no idea how many contracts they will win, if any. The result is usually a shortage of qualified resources.

Causes of Conflicts in Project Management

- **Third**, projects are often approved and added to the queue without knowing when the project will begin. **Once the project officially begins, the qualifications or work habits of the assigned project team members may not fit the needs of the project.** And, as expected, you are then told that these are the only resources that are available.

Causes of Conflicts in Project Management

- **Fourth, your project must be accomplished without disrupting the ongoing business of your company and other projects being performed.** If your project has a low priority, then you must expect that your most critical resources may be temporarily removed to put out fires elsewhere in the company. These conflicts are highly probable in non–project-driven companies.
- **Fifth, the type of organizational structure can create conflicts.** As an example, line managers that perform in a matrix structure are under tremendous pressure to staff a multitude of projects possibly at the same time. A delay on one project could result in a late release of personnel needed to staff new projects about to begin.

Approaches to Addressing Conflicts in Project Management

Conflict Resolution Modes

The management of conflicts places the project manager in the precarious situation of having to select a conflict resolution mode. Based upon the situation, the type of conflict, and whom the conflict is with, any of these modes could be justified.

- **Confronting (or Collaborating)** With this approach, the conflicting parties meet face to face and try to work through their disagreements. This approach should focus more on solving the problem and less on being combative. This approach is collaboration and integration where both parties need to win. This method should be used:

Conflict Resolution Modes

- When you and the conflicting party can both get at least what you wanted and maybe more
- To reduce cost
- To create a common power base
- To attack a common foe
- When skills are complementary
- When there is enough time
- When there is trust
- When you have confidence in the other person's ability
- When the ultimate objective is to learn

Conflict Resolution Modes

- **Compromising** To compromise is to bargain or to search for solutions so both parties leave with some degree of satisfaction. Compromising is often the result of confrontation. Some people argue that compromise is a “give-and-take” approach, which leads to a “win-win” position. Others argue that compromise is a “lose-lose” position, since neither party gets everything he/she wants or needs. **Compromise should be used:**
 - When both parties need to be winners
 - When you can't win
 - When others are as strong as you are
 - When you haven't time to win
 - To maintain your relationship with your opponent

Conflict Resolution Modes

- When you are not sure you are right
- When you get nothing if you don't
- When stakes are moderate
- To avoid giving the impression of “fighting”

Conflict Resolution Modes

- **Smoothing (or Accommodating)**

Smoothing is an attempt to reduce the emotions that exist in a conflict. This is accomplished by emphasizing areas of agreement and deemphasizing areas of disagreement. An example of smoothing would be to tell someone, “We have agreed on three of the five points and there is no reason why we cannot agree on the last two points.” Smoothing does not necessarily resolve a conflict, but tries to convince both parties to remain at the bargaining table because a solution is possible. In smoothing, one may sacrifice one’s own goals in order to satisfy the needs of the other party. **Smoothing should be used:**

Conflict Resolution Modes

- To reach an overarching goal
- To create obligation for a trade-off at a later date
- When the stakes are low
- When liability is limited
- To maintain harmony
- When any solution will be adequate
- To create goodwill (be magnanimous)
- When you'll lose anyway
- To gain time

Conflict Resolution Modes

- **Forcing (or Competing, Being Assertive)**

This is what happens when one party tries to impose the solution on being uncooperative with the other party. Conflict resolution works best when resolution is achieved at the lowest possible levels. The higher up the conflict goes, the greater the tendency for the conflict to be forced, with the result being a “win-lose” situation in which one party wins at the expense of the other.

Conflict Resolution Modes

- When you are right
- When a do-or-die situation exists
- When stakes are high
- When important principles are at stake
- When you are stronger (never start a battle you can't win)
- To gain status or to gain power
- In short-term, one-shot deals
- When the relationship is unimportant
- When it's understood that a game is being played
- When a quick decision must be made

Conflict Resolution Modes

Avoiding (or Withdrawing) Avoidance is often regarded as a temporary solution to a problem. The problem and the resulting conflict can come up again and again. Some people view avoiding as cowardice and an unwillingness to be responsive to a situation.

- Avoiding should be used:
- When you can't win
- When the stakes are low
- When the stakes are high, but you are not ready yet
- To gain time

Conflict Resolution Modes

- To unnerve your opponent
- To preserve neutrality or reputation
- When you think the problem will go away
- When you win by delay

Conflict Resolution Modes

Conflict Resolution Modes Summarised

- **Withdrawal** is retreating from a potential conflict.
- **Smoothing** is emphasizing areas of agreement and deemphasizing areas of disagreement.
- **Compromising** is the willingness to give and take.
- **Forcing** is directing the resolution in one direction or another, a win-or-lose position.
- **Confrontation** is a face-to-face meeting to resolve the conflict.

Important Questions in Conflict Resolution

The ability to handle conflicts may start by asking and understanding a few questions as presented below:

- Why do conflicts occur?
- How can conflicts be resolved?
- Is there any type of analysis that could identify possible conflicts before they occur?
- What are the project objectives and are they in conflict with other projects?
- Is there a set priority?

Setting Priorities as a means of resolving conflicts

Many executives feel that the best way to resolve conflicts is by establishing priorities. This may be true as long as priorities are not continually shifted around.

The most common factors influencing the establishment of project priorities are as presented below:

Factors influencing the establishment of project priorities

- The technical risks in development
- The risks that the company will incur, financially or competitively
- The nearness of the delivery date and the urgency
- The penalties that can accompany late delivery dates
- The expected savings, profit increase, and return on investment
- The amount of influence that the customer possesses, possibly due to the size of the project
- The impact on other projects or product lines
- The impact on affiliated organizations

Conflict Resolution Procedures in Organisation

The development of company-wide conflict resolution policies and procedures.

- Many companies have attempted to develop **company-wide policies** and procedures for conflict resolution, but this method is often doomed to failure because each project and conflict is different. Furthermore, project managers, by virtue of their individuality, and sometimes differing amounts of authority and responsibility, **prefer to resolve conflicts in their own fashion**.

Conflict Resolution Procedures in Organisation

The establishment of project conflict resolution procedures during the early planning activities.

- One method that is often very effective is to “plan” for conflicts during the planning activities. This can be accomplished through the use of linear responsibility charts. Planning for conflict resolution is similar to the first method except that each project manager can develop his or her own policies, rules, and procedures.

Conflict Resolution Procedures in Organisation

The use of hierarchical referral

- In theory, this appears as the best method because neither the project manager nor the functional manager will dominate. Under this arrangement, the project and functional managers agree that for a proper balance to exist their common superior must resolve the conflict to protect the company's best interest. Unfortunately, this is not realistic because the common superior cannot be expected to continually resolve lower-level conflicts, and it gives the impression that the functional and project managers cannot resolve their own problems.

Conflict Resolution Procedures in Organisation

The requirement of direct contact

- This is direct contact in which conflicting parties meet face to face and resolve their disagreement. Unfortunately, this method does not always work and, if continually stressed, can result in conditions where individuals will either suppress the identification of problems or develop new ones during confrontation. Many conflicts can be either reduced or eliminated by constant communication of the project objectives to the team members. This continual repetition may prevent individuals from going too far in the wrong direction.

Organising Direct Contact Conflict Resolution Meetings

If a direct contact or confrontational meeting is necessary between conflicting parties, then the project manager should be aware of the logical steps and sequence of events that should be taken.

Often, these includes:

- Setting the climate: establishing a willingness to participate
- Analysing the images: how do you see yourself and others, and how do they see you?
- Collecting the information: getting feelings out in the open
- Defining the problem: defining and clarifying all positions
- Sharing the information: making the information available to all

Organising Direct Contact Conflict Resolution Meetings

- Setting the appropriate priorities: developing working sessions for setting priorities and timetables
- Organizing the group: forming cross-functional problem-solving groups
- Problem-solving: obtaining cross-functional involvement, securing commitments, and setting the priorities and timetable
- Developing the action plan: getting commitment
- Implementing the work: taking action on the plan.
- Following up: obtaining feedback on the implementation for the action plan.

Steps to Preventing Conflict

Conflict minimization procedures.

- Pausing and thinking before reacting
- Building trust
- Trying to understand the conflict motives
- Keeping the meeting under control
- listening to all involved parties
- Maintaining a give-and-take attitude
- Educating others tactfully on your views
- Being willing to say when you were wrong
- Not acting as a superman and levelling the discussion only once in a while

Attributes of An Effective Manager in Conflict Resolution

Thus, the effective manager, in conflict problem-solving situations:

- Knows the organization
- listens with understanding rather than evaluation
- Clarifies the nature of the conflict
- Understands the feelings of others
- Suggests the procedures for resolving differences
- Maintains relationships with disputing parties
- Facilitates the communications process
- Seeks resolutions

Understanding Superior, Subordinate and Functional Conflicts

In order for the project manager to be effective, he must understand how to work with the various employees who interface with the project. These employees include upper-level management, subordinate project team members, and functional personnel.

The project manager must demonstrate an ability for continuous adaptability by **creating a different working environment with each group of employees.** The **type and intensity of conflicts** can also vary with the type of employee see immediate figure below.

Relationship between conflict causes and sources.

		SOURCES: CONFLICTS OCCURRED MOSTLY WITH					
		FUNCTIONAL MANAGERS	FUNCTIONAL PERSONNEL	BETWEEN PROJECT PERSONNEL	SUPERIORS	SUBORDINATES	
CONFLICT CAUSES	SCHEDULES	☐	☐				HIGH ↑ RELATIVE CONFLICT INTENSITY ↓ LOW
	PRIORITIES	☐	☐	☐			
	MANPOWER	☐	☐				
	TECHNICAL	☐	☐	☐			
	PROCEDURES	☐	☐		☐	☐	
	PERSONALITY	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
	COSTS	☐	☐		☐		
		HIGH ← RELATIVE CONFLICT INTENSITY → LOW					

Understanding Superior, Subordinate and Functional Conflicts

The specific resolution mode a project manager will use might easily depend on whom the conflict is with, as shown in the immediate figure below. The figure below identifies the modes that will increase or decrease the potential conflict intensity. For example, although project managers consider, in general, that **withdrawal is their least favourite mode, it can be used quite effectively with functional managers.** In dealing with superiors, project managers would rather be ready for an immediate compromise than for face-to-face confrontation that could favour upper-level management.

Association between Perceived Intensity of Conflict and Mode of Conflict Resolution.

INTENSITY OF CONFLICT PERCEIVED BY PROJECT MANAGERS (P.M.)	ACTUAL CONFLICT RESOLUTION STYLE				
	FORCING	CONFRONTATION	COMPROMISE	SMOOTHING	WITHDRAWAL
BETWEEN P.M. AND HIS PERSONNEL					
BETWEEN P.M. AND HIS SUPERIOR					
BETWEEN P.M. AND FUNCTIONAL SUPPORT DEPARTMENTS					

 STRONGLY FAVORABLE ASSOCIATION WITH REGARD TO LOW CONFLICT ($- \tau$)

 STRONGLY UNFAVORABLE ASSOCIATION WITH REGARD TO LOW CONFLICT ($+ \tau$)

Understanding Superior, Subordinate and Functional Conflicts

The figure below identifies the various influence styles that project managers find effective in helping to reduce potential conflicts. Penalty power, authority, and expertise are considered as strongly unfavourable associations with respect to low conflicts. As expected, work challenge and promotions (if the project manager has the authority) are strongly favourable.

Association between influence methods of project managers and their perceived conflict intensity.

INTENSITY OF CONFLICT PERCEIVED BY PROJECT MANAGER (P.M.)	INFLUENCE METHODS AS PERCEIVED BY PROJECT MANAGERS						
	EXPERTISE	AUTHORITY	WORK CHALLENGE	FRIENDSHIP	PROMOTION	SALARY	PENALTY
BETWEEN P.M. AND HIS PERSONNEL	□	□	△		△		□
BETWEEN P.M. AND HIS SUPERIOR			△				□
BETWEEN P.M. AND FUNCTIONAL SUPPORT DEPARTMENTS		□					□

△ STRONGLY FAVORABLE ASSOCIATION WITH REGARD TO LOW CONFLICT ($- \tau$)

□ STRONGLY UNFAVORABLE ASSOCIATION WITH REGARD TO LOW CONFLICT ($+ \tau$)

Looking Back at the Lecture Outcomes

Based on this lecture's outcomes, do you think you can manage conflict in your teamwork?

Are you ready to be professional in your teamwork?

Reflect on these as you embark on the semester's project

Lecture Resources

Recommended reading:

Project Management - A Multi-disciplinary Approach (4th edition)
Chapter 7: Conflicts

Next Topic

- **Team Dynamics** continues in the next lecture material



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